



For Staff

Cyberbullying and Online Abuse

Responding when a student is threatened, humiliated or encouraged to self-harm online, including by an anonymous account

Content Warning

This guide covers online bullying, threats of violence and encouragement to self-harm.

This is reference guidance, not a training course. Use it to check how to respond, or to prepare for a conversation. It does not replace the school's safeguarding training, policy or the DSL's advice on a specific case.

It contains descriptions of online bullying, threats of violence, messages encouraging self-harm and suicide (without any detail of methods), and abuse targeting race, faith, disability, sexuality and gender identity. Some of it may be difficult to read, particularly if it connects with your own experience or that of someone close to you.

- You can read it in sections, take a break, or step away at any point.
- If this raises something personal, you can speak in confidence to your line manager, a senior colleague you trust, or the school's Employee Assistance Programme, if it has one, or **Education Support** (free, confidential, 24/7 on 08000 562 561). **Samaritans** is free and open any time, day or night, on 116 123.
- If you have a question about how this guidance applies to a situation you are dealing with, speak to your school's Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).

If reading this makes you worried about a child now, do not wait until you have finished reading: speak to the DSL or a deputy straight away. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response. **Go to the Quick Reference Card.**

Why This Matters

Online bullying is part of ordinary school life, not a separate world. In Ofcom's 2026 research, **almost a quarter (23%) of 8 to 17 year olds had personally experienced nasty or hurtful behaviour in the previous 12 months**, and nearly half of them (47%) said it happened through social media ([Ofcom, 2026](#)). In the most recent national statistics on online bullying, **72% of 10 to 15 year olds who had experienced it said at least some of it happened at school or during school time** ([ONS, year ending March 2020](#)).

KCSIE 2026 lists bullying, including cyberbullying and prejudice-based and discriminatory bullying, as child-on-child abuse (paragraph 37), and recognises that serious bullying, including cyberbullying, can be emotional abuse when it causes children frequently to feel frightened or in danger (paragraph 27). Online bullying is one of the "conduct" risks of online safety (paragraph 165), and every school's behaviour policy should include measures to prevent bullying, including cyberbullying (paragraph 123). When messages threaten violence or encourage self-harm, this is no longer only a behaviour matter: it is a safeguarding concern that needs action today.

Scenario Overview

A Year 8 student shows you threatening messages from an anonymous account, including threats of violence and encouragement to self-harm.

What to Keep in Mind

- **Two immediate risks:** to the student's life and wellbeing (encouragement to self-harm) and to their physical safety (threats of violence). Tell the DSL **immediately**.
- **Ask directly about self-harm.** Talking about it openly does not put the idea in someone's head (Samaritans).
- **Anonymous does not mean unknown to the student**, and it does not mean a stranger. Don't try to find out who: that is for the DSL and, where relevant, the police.
- **Evidence matters, but you are not the investigator.** Never view, copy, forward or delete a nude or semi-nude image. For other messages, note what you saw and let the DSL decide how the evidence is preserved.
- **Bullying, child-on-child abuse and crime overlap.** You don't need to decide which this is, and staff never decide whether an offence has been committed.

- Online bullying is often repeated. **A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before reporting a concern.** A single threat or a single message encouraging self-harm needs action straight away.
- The person responsible may well be **a child too**, and would need a safeguarding response as well as consequences.

How RESPOND Works in This Scenario

RESPOND is powered by **ACT: Active Intervention** (inaction is not neutral; "just block them" is not a response), **Contextual Safeguarding** (online abuse runs through peer groups, group chats and platforms, and follows students home) and **Trauma-Informed Practice** (safety before emotion before thinking). The steps are taught in order but work as a **helix**: see *The RESPOND Helix* section.

Step	RESPOND tool	In this scenario
● Recognise	4 Ps Context Scan; Escalation of Unseen Harm	Threats, self-harm encouragement and anonymity: two immediate risks
● Engage	TED questions; the disclosure script; 4Ds, if it is safe to do so	Believe them; look only at what they show you; ask directly about self-harm
● Support	Safety check first; "Your calm is contagious"	Self-harm risk and physical safety today; stay with them
● Pause	90-second grounding; Three Lenses (Risk, Rights, Resources)	Don't investigate the account, copy messages to your device, or confront anyone
● Offer	Model alternatives; if in doubt, N before O	Don't reply, don't retaliate, keep it, tell; explain what happens next
● Notify	DSL, immediately where there is immediate risk; 999 for immediate danger	In person, now; another adult stays with the student
● Document	GOLD standard	Their words, and what you saw: platform, account name, times, the words of the threats

RESPOND is not a checklist to complete in order. Immediate danger or possible risk to life: act first (999 when needed, stay with the child, summon the DSL or a deputy), then return to the steps.

Need the essentials? The *Quick Reference Card* at the end of this guide covers the immediate response and escalation on one page.

The One Chance Rule: a disclosure may be a young person's only attempt to seek help. Make it count.

The RESPOND Helix: How the Steps Move

RESPOND is taught in a line, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. In practice it moves as a helix. The first dimension is the steps themselves: you may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. The second is time and severity: each turn sits higher as a concern develops. The third is context: a concern involving several children, places or platforms traces a wider spiral.

Relational and Systemic

For a child, safeguarding is **relational**: it happens through people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: the steps, records and shared decisions that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help.

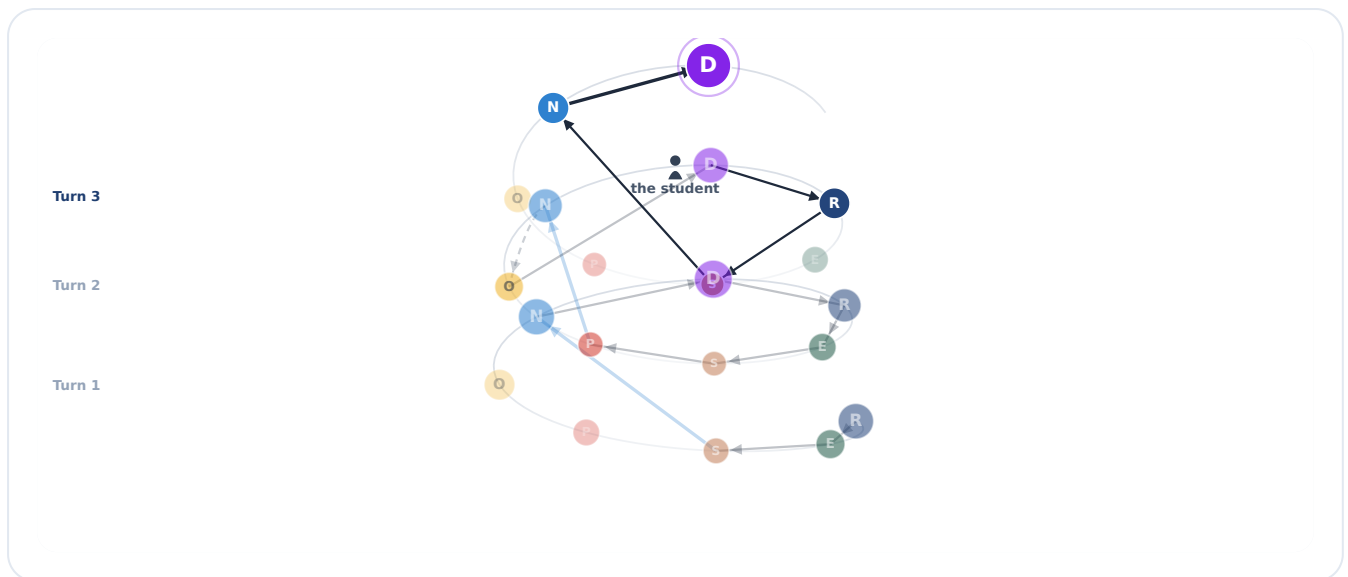
Relational is why children tell. Systemic is why telling works.

The RESPOND steps follow the same shape: Recognise, Engage and Support are relational; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps. Neither works alone. Relationship without the system becomes secrecy, which is why staff never promise to keep a disclosure to themselves. The system without relationship becomes process that children do not trust enough to use. When you share information, be open with the child about what you are sharing and why.

See It Move

One example: an anonymous account sending threats and messages encouraging self-harm, over three weeks. Then see a wider spiral, where a group chat and a peer group are involved, and what happens when steps are skipped.

This is a still image of the interactive RESPOND Helix. Open the web version of this guide to step through the examples; every example is also written out in full below.



▼ Read the helix demonstration as text

Sequence

How RESPOND is taught.

1. **The seven steps:** RESPOND is taught in this order, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. Recognise, Engage and Support are the relational steps; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps.
2. **But practice is not a line:** Online abuse often builds over days or weeks, then spikes. When a message threatens violence or encourages self-harm, you go straight to Notify. Choose an example to see how the steps move.

An anonymous account

A Year 8 student receives messages from an anonymous account over three weeks. The sender is unknown; the helix wraps around the student.

1. **Turn 1: something is wrong:** A tutor notices a Year 8 student flinching when her phone buzzes at the end of the day, and sitting apart at lunch. Recognise: use the 4 Ps. Platforms matter here, and you don't need a disclosure.
2. **Turn 1: Engage:** a quiet check-in. "Tell me how things are going at the moment." She says "someone keeps messaging me" but doesn't want to say more. Don't push, and don't ask to see her phone.
3. **Turn 1: Support:** tell her she can come back to you at any time, and that if anything online frightens her or tells her to hurt herself, she should tell an adult straight away.
4. **Turn 1: Notify:** pass it to the DSL the same day. One worried observation is often the first piece of a pattern, and the DSL may hold other pieces.
5. **Turn 1: Document:** GOLD. What you saw, what she said, in her words, and what you did.
6. **Turn 2: the messages (a week later):** She comes to you at break and shows you messages from an account with no name or photo: threats to "get" her after school, and messages telling her to hurt herself. Two immediate risks.
7. **Turn 2: Engage:** stay calm and use the script. "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next." Look only at what she chooses to show you. Don't scroll or take the phone.

8. **Turn 2:** Support: ask directly and calmly whether the messages have made her think about hurting herself. Stay with her, in a private space. Ask about today: the journey home, and whether she thinks the sender knows where she will be.
9. **Turn 2: hold:** Pause for 90 seconds, then Three Lenses. Hold here on purpose: don't message the account, try to work out who it is, photograph the screen with your own phone, or ask her to forward anything to you.
10. **Turn 2: N before O:** Notify: the DSL, immediately and in person, while another adult stays with her. The DSL assesses the self-harm risk and the threat, decides how the messages are preserved, and considers the police and parents.
1. **Turn 2:** Offer, once the DSL is involved: model alternatives. Don't reply, don't retaliate, keep the messages, and block and report when the DSL has agreed how the evidence is kept. Explain what happens next.
2. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD, as soon as is practicably possible. Her exact words, and what you saw: the platform, the account name, the dates and times, and the words of the threats as they appeared.
3. **Turn 3: it moves (two weeks later):** The account is blocked, but a new one appears with a similar name, and a photo of her is posted in a year group chat with mocking comments. Because the first concerns were recorded, the DSL can link them.
4. **Turn 3: loop back:** Loop back to Recognise: this is a pattern across accounts and platforms, and now a peer group is involved. A pattern helps explain, but nobody waited for it.
5. **Turn 3:** Support: check in with her, including about self-harm, again. Ask what would help at school. The support plan is reviewed, not assumed to be working.
6. **Turn 3:** Notify: the DSL, the same day. The DSL now also considers the students who shared the photo, and the bystanders who reported it.
7. **Turn 3:** Document: GOLD, linked to the earlier records, so the chronology is visible.

Wider spiral

Online abuse spreads through a peer group. One chat, three strands moving at once.

1. **Three strands:** A humiliating edited photo of a Year 8 student is shared in a year group chat. Some students add comments; many see it and say nothing. A single concern traces a tight spiral; this one is wider.
2. **At the same time:** Support the student targeted, including a self-harm check. Pause before any contact with the students who shared it: the DSL plans that. A bystander who reported it is thanked and listened to.
3. **At the same time:** The student targeted and the students sharing both go to the DSL. The bystander is reassured that telling was right, and asked to stop sharing, not to collect proof.
4. **Joined up:** Offer, once the DSL has decided: accountability and learning for those who shared; support and choices for the student targeted; for bystanders, how to report and support, if it is safe to do so.
5. **Every strand:** Every strand ends in Document. The group's part is part of the pattern, and belongs in the record.

When it breaks

The same Year 8 student and the anonymous account, when steps are skipped.

1. **Turn 1:** The student shows a teacher the threats and the messages telling her to hurt herself. Recognise happens.
2. **Support skipped:** The adult says, "Just block them and stay off that app." No one asks how she is, or about self-harm. Support is skipped, and she hears that it was her problem to fix.
3. **Pause skipped:** The adult asks her to forward the messages to his own phone, then confronts a student he suspects. Pause is skipped: the evidence is now on a personal device, and the sender knows she has told.
4. **Notify and Document skipped:** Nothing reaches the DSL, and nothing is recorded. When the new account appears, there is nothing to connect it to.
5. **The helix fragments:** The messages get worse. She has learned that telling makes it worse, and stops telling. That is how harm escalates unseen.
6. **Put it back together:** Every step taken puts the structure back. Relational is why children tell; systemic is why telling works.

The Helix is described in the RESPOND Safeguarding Operating System (section 5.2). All examples are fictional.

R

RECOGNISE: Identify the Harm and the Risk

Online abuse is real abuse. It can reach a young person at any hour, in front of a large audience, from someone they cannot see. Recognise two things: what is happening, and how urgent it is.

The 4 Ps Context Scan

People

Who is involved? An anonymous account, a group, a former friend? Who is joining in, and who has seen it? Could an adult be involved?

Places

Where does it spill over? Corridors, lunch, the bus, clubs, the boarding house. Where will the student be after school today?

Platforms

Messaging apps, social media, gaming, group chats, comments, fake or anonymous profiles, edited or AI-generated images

Patterns

When do messages arrive? Evenings, weekends, night? Is it spreading to new accounts or platforms? Getting worse?

Two Immediate Risks in This Scenario

- **Encouragement to self-harm:** a risk to the student's life and wellbeing. Ask about it directly, stay with them, and tell the DSL immediately.
- **Threats of violence:** a risk to their physical safety, possibly today. Find out when and where the student is worried about, and tell the DSL immediately.
- If the student has been seriously hurt, has harmed themselves, or you believe they cannot keep themselves safe, call 999.

What Online Abuse Can Look Like

Threats and Intimidation

- Threats to hurt the student, or "get" them at a particular time or place
- Messages showing the sender knows where they live, travel or will be
- Repeated messages from new accounts after one is blocked

Encouragement to Self-Harm

- Messages telling the student to hurt themselves, or to end their life
- Messages saying everyone would be better off without them
- Sharing harmful self-harm or suicide content with them

Humiliation and Exclusion

- Mocking posts, polls, memes or edited photos, in group chats or public
- Fake profiles impersonating the student
- Removing them from group chats, or organising others to ignore them

Identity-Based Abuse

- Racist, faith-targeted, homophobic, biphobic or transphobic slurs
- Mocking disability, SEND, appearance or accent
- Sexist or sexualised comments, including about bodies or reputations

Signs a Student May Be Experiencing Online Abuse

- Anxious, jumpy or tearful when their phone or device notifies them; hiding the screen
- Withdrawing from friends, avoiding places such as the canteen, bus or changing rooms
- Tiredness, which may mean messages are arriving at night; falling attendance or attainment
- Changes in mood, low self-worth, or talk of being a burden or of "making it stop"
- Signs of self-harm, or a sudden, unexplained calm after a period of distress

KCSIE 2026 notes that mental health problems can develop into safeguarding concerns, including self-harm, suicidal ideation or risk of suicide, and that staff are well placed to notice warning signs such as withdrawing from social situations and significant changes in behaviour (paragraphs 47 and 48).

Signs a Student May Be Involved in Harming Others Online

- Talking about, laughing at or showing others content about a particular student
- A friendship group that has suddenly turned on one student
- Justifying it as "banter", "a joke" or "they started it"

Some students who harm others online have been targeted themselves, or are going along with a group out of fear. That shapes the support they need; it does not reduce the response.

No Disclosure Needed

Many young people won't call it bullying: in national data, more than half (52%) of 10 to 15 year olds who had experienced online bullying behaviour would not describe it as bullying, and a quarter (26%) had told no one (ONS, 2020). If you notice the signs, pass them to the DSL **without waiting for a disclosure**, and record what you saw and heard, factually.

Anonymous Accounts

- Not knowing who is behind an account often increases fear. The student may begin to suspect friends, and withdraw from everyone.

- Anonymous does not mean untraceable. Platforms and the police have ways to identify account holders; schools do not, and should not try.
- It could be a student, several people, or an adult posing as a young person. Any request for images, sexual contact or a meeting is a separate and urgent concern: tell the DSL immediately.
- The student may have a guess. Record it as their words ("She said she thinks it might be..."), not as fact, and don't act on it yourself.

Bullying, Child-on-Child Abuse and Crime: What the Law Says (England and Wales)

One set of messages can fall into all three frames. Know the difference; leave the decisions to the DSL.

Frame	What it means	Who decides
Bullying	There is no single legal definition. The Anti-Bullying Alliance defines it as "the repetitive, intentional hurting of one person or group by another person or group, where the relationship involves an imbalance of power", face-to-face or online (ABA). Not all bullying is a crime, but some forms are illegal, such as threats, repeated harassment and hate crimes (GOV.UK).	The school, under its behaviour and anti-bullying policies
Child-on-child abuse	A safeguarding category, not a crime. KCSIE 2026 lists bullying (including cyberbullying, prejudice-based and discriminatory bullying) and discriminatory behaviour as child-on-child abuse, and notes that physical abuse may include an online element which threatens or encourages it (paragraph 37). It should never be passed off as "banter" or "just having a laugh" (paragraph 193).	The DSL, under the child protection policy
Criminal offences	Some online behaviour can also be a crime, depending on what was sent, the intent and the circumstances. Criminal responsibility in England and Wales starts at 10.	The police and the Crown Prosecution Service, never school staff

- **Threatening communications:** sending a message that conveys a threat of death or serious harm, intending the recipient to fear it will be carried out, or reckless as to whether they will (Online Safety Act 2023, section 181).
- **Encouraging or assisting serious self-harm:** doing an act capable of encouraging or assisting another person's serious self-harm, intending to do so. The offence can be committed whether or not self-harm occurs (Online Safety Act 2023, section 184).
- **Encouraging or assisting suicide** is an offence under the Suicide Act 1961, section 2, even where no attempt takes place (CPS).
- **Indecent or grossly offensive messages** sent to cause distress or anxiety (Malicious Communications Act 1988, section 1).

- **Harassment:** a course of conduct, meaning conduct on at least two occasions, that alarms or distresses someone; conduct includes speech (Protection from Harassment Act 1997, section 7).
- **Hate crime:** any offence can be prosecuted as a hate crime where the offender shows, or is motivated by, hostility based on race, religion, disability, sexual orientation or transgender identity (CPS).
- **Nude or sexual images** of anyone under 18, including AI-generated images, involve criminal offences; schools follow the UKCIS advice (KCSIE 2026, Part five).

For young people, the CPS says prosecutors should give the age and maturity of suspects "significant weight", because children may not appreciate the harm and seriousness of their communications (CPS; age of criminal responsibility).

Staff should not decide whether an offence has been committed. Describe what you saw and heard, and report it to the DSL. Legal references checked 28 September 2026.

The School's Anti-Bullying Duty

- **Every school** should have a behaviour policy that includes measures to prevent bullying, including cyberbullying, prejudice-based and discriminatory bullying (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 11 and 123).
- **Maintained schools:** the headteacher must set measures to prevent all forms of bullying among students, and these may cover behaviour when students are off site, to the extent that is reasonable (Education and Inspections Act 2006, section 89).
- **Independent schools:** the proprietor must ensure bullying is prevented, so far as reasonably practicable, through an effective anti-bullying strategy (Independent School Standards, paragraph 10).
- DfE advice: Preventing and tackling bullying. Abuse sent at night or at weekends still comes into school.

What the Data Shows

23%

of 8 to 17 year olds had personally experienced nasty or hurtful behaviour in the past 12 months

Ofcom, 2026

19%

of 10 to 15 year olds experienced at least one type of online bullying behaviour in a year

ONS, 2020

72%

of those experienced at least some of it at school or during school time

ONS, 2020

10.8%

of 11 to 16 year olds with a probable mental disorder said they had been bullied online, compared with 2.6% of those unlikely to have one

NHS England, 2023

Ofcom surveyed children aged 8 to 17 (published May 2026). The ONS figures (Crime Survey for England and Wales, year ending March 2020) are the most recent official statistics on online bullying, but are now several years old. The NHS figures show an association, not a cause. Checked 28 September 2026.

E

ENGAGE: Listen, Believe, Ask About Safety

When a student shows you messages, your first response shapes whether they keep telling. Stay calm, believe them, look only at what they choose to show you, and ask directly about their safety.

What a Student Might Say

"Someone's been sending me stuff. I don't know who it is. They said they're going to get me after school, and they keep telling me to hurt myself."

The RESPOND disclosure script:

"I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."

- **Thank them:** "Thank you for showing me. You've done exactly the right thing."
- **TED:** "Tell me what's been happening." "Explain when the messages started." "Describe how you've been feeling since." Never "why": it can sound like blame.
- **Ask directly about self-harm:** "Some of these messages tell you to hurt yourself. Have you had thoughts of hurting yourself, or of ending your life?" Stay calm whatever the answer.
- **Ask about the threat:** "Are you worried about something happening today? Where, and when?"
- **Look only at what they show you.** Don't take the phone, scroll through it, or ask to see more. If anything sexual appears, look away and stop.

Helpful

- "No one deserves messages like this."
- "Online harm is real harm. I'm taking it seriously."
- "You don't have to reply, and you don't have to sort this out on your own."

Unhelpful

- "Just block them" or "Just ignore it." (dismisses the risk, and can lose evidence)
- "You shouldn't be on that app at your age." (blame)
- "It's only online, it's not real." (minimising)
- "Show me everything on your phone." (investigating, and could expose you to illegal content)
- "I'll make sure they're excluded." (a promise you can't keep)

If a Friend or Bystander Tells You

"Someone in our year keeps posting stuff about her from a fake account. It's getting really nasty. Everyone's seen it."

- **Thank them:** "Thank you for telling me. That was the right thing to do."
- **TED:** "Tell me what you've seen." "Describe where it's being shared."
- **Don't ask them to screenshot, forward, keep watching, or find out who it is.** That is not their job, and sharing can spread the harm.
- They may fear being targeted next: tell them you'll pass it on carefully.

If You See It Happening

If you see students crowding round a phone laughing at a post about another student, or passing round an image, act **if it is safe to do so**, using the 4Ds: **Direct** ("Put the phone away, please"), **Distract** (move the group on, or give the student targeted a reason to come with you), **Delegate** (get a colleague or the DSL), **Delay** (check in privately with the student afterwards). Don't take the phone to look at the content; if it may be sexual, tell the DSL straight away.



SUPPORT: Safety First

Safety comes before everything else: the self-harm risk, the threat, and what happens today. Your calm is contagious.

Safety Check Questions

Self-Harm

- "Have the messages made you think about hurting yourself?"
- "Have you hurt yourself?" "Are you thinking about it now?"

Physical

- "Do you think this person knows where you'll be today?"
- "How are you getting home? Who will be with you?"

Digital

- "Are the messages still coming? On which apps?"
- "Has anything personal been shared, like your address or photos?"

Today and Tonight

- "What are you worried about for the rest of today, and tonight?"

If the Student Has Thought About Hurting Themselves

- **Stay with them.** Send another adult for the DSL; don't leave the student alone or send them to find someone.
- "Thank you for telling me. You're not on your own with this. We're going to get you some help now."
- Don't ask about methods or details beyond what you need to keep them safe. The DSL leads the risk assessment and the route to mental health support.
- If they need medical help, get first aid; call 999 if their life may be at risk or they cannot keep themselves safe.

Immediate Practical Support

- A private, quiet space; water; time; the option not to go straight back to lessons
- Let them decide whether to keep their phone with them, put it away, or turn notifications off for now. Don't take it as a punishment, and don't read through it
- Ask them not to delete anything and not to reply to the account

SEND, Neurodivergence and Language

- Allow extra processing time and a quiet space. Use clear, concrete language; avoid idioms, sarcasm and double questions.
- Some students may find it harder to tell a joke from a threat, or to recognise manipulation online, and may be targeted because of it.
- Use a professional interpreter where language is a barrier, never another student or a family member.
- Record any adjustments you made.

Support for Everyone Involved

Everyone involved needs a response, planned by the DSL.

The Student Targeted

- Safety planning, in school and online
- A named trusted adult and regular check-ins
- Mental health support, including a self-harm risk assessment

Bystanders

- Thanks, and reassurance that telling was right
- Protection if they fear being targeted
- Support if they have seen distressing content

The Student or Students Responsible

- Clear boundaries and consequences under the behaviour policy
- Exploring what sits behind it, including whether they have been targeted or pressured themselves
- Support without excuses: accountability and help go together

P

PAUSE: Consider Your Approach

Act with composure. Take 90 seconds: breathe, lower your shoulders, check your own state. The urge to find out who it is, or grab the evidence, is strong: Pause is where you stop.

Three Lenses

Lens	In this scenario
Risk	Is the student at risk of self-harm now? Is the threat specific: a time, a place, knowledge of where they live? Is personal information or an image being shared? Could an adult be involved?
Rights	The student's right to be safe, heard and believed, and to a say in what happens; the right of the students responsible, who are likely children too, to a fair and safeguarding response
Resources	The DSL, the school's mental health lead or counsellor, pastoral staff, the police, platforms and reporting services, and the safe adults in the student's life

What You Must Not Do

Don't Investigate

- Don't try to identify the account, search social media, or look at the student's other apps
- Don't message the account, even to tell them to stop
- Don't ask other students who it is, or ask them to find out

Don't Copy, Forward or Search

- **Never view, copy, forward or delete a nude or semi-nude image** of a young person, even as evidence. If one appears, stop, secure the situation and tell the DSL (UKCIS).
- Don't photograph the screen with your own phone or ask the student to forward messages to you or your email
- For other messages, **the DSL decides how evidence is preserved**. Note what you saw instead
- Only the headteacher, or staff they authorise, can search a student's device (DfE)

Don't Confront

- Don't speak to a student you or they suspect, or warn them off
- It can escalate the abuse, move it somewhere harder to see, and lead to evidence being deleted

Don't Promise Secrecy or Outcomes

"I'm really glad you showed me. I can't keep this to myself, because I'm worried about your safety. I'll need to speak to the DSL right now, whose job is to help keep you safe. I'll only share it with people who need to know, and I'll tell you what's happening."

- Don't promise the messages will stop, or that anyone will be excluded or arrested

Don't Minimise or Blame

- Not "just drama", "banter" or "only online"
- Not "you shouldn't have been on that app" or "why didn't you tell someone sooner?"

Check Your Own Response

- Check whether you are treating this as less serious because it is online, or because you are less confident with technology. You don't need to be an expert: believe, protect, report
- If you feel overwhelmed: "This is important and I want to get it right. I'm going to stay with you while a colleague fetches the DSL."
- Afterwards, look after yourself. Talk to the DSL or your line manager. Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff.



OFFER: Model Alternatives

Offer proportionate options without coercion, explain what happens next, and model a different way to respond to online abuse. If in doubt, N before O: with two immediate risks, the DSL is involved before you offer options.

Explain What Happens Next

"Here's what happens now. I'm going to get our safeguarding lead, whose job is to keep you safe, and I'll stay with you until they're here. They'll talk with you about how you're feeling and decide how the messages are kept, so please don't delete them or reply. They may speak to the police about the threats, and your parents or carers will usually need to know; we'll talk with you about how. None of this is your fault. What questions do you have?"

Be honest about information sharing. Staff should share safeguarding information as early as possible, and data protection law does not prevent it; safeguarding children is a lawful basis for sharing sensitive information without consent where appropriate (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 142 to 148). What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. From 30 September 2026, the Information Sharing Duty (section 16LA, Children Act 2004) also requires the organisations it covers to share where its tests are met; the DSL

decides how it applies. So don't ask for consent as if it were the legal basis. Tell the student what will be shared, with whom and why, unless that would increase the risk, and listen to their views: they shape the plan. Agreeing to a service, such as counselling, is a separate question, and their agreement matters there.

Options, Not Orders

- "Would you like me to stay while you talk to the DSL?"
- "How would you like your parents told: with you there, or with us leading?"
- "What would help at break and lunch, and on the way home?"

Some things have to happen to keep them safe, such as telling the DSL and, usually, parents. Where there is a choice, give it to them.

Model the Alternative

Safer Responses

- Don't reply, and don't retaliate
- Keep the messages; don't delete them
- Tell a trusted adult
- Block and report, once the DSL has agreed how evidence is kept

Responses That Make It Worse

- Replying, arguing or threatening back
- Setting up an account to "get back at" them
- Trying to work out who it is, or accusing friends
- Deleting everything and saying nothing

Blocking and reporting protect the student and are their right. Where you can, agree the timing with the DSL so that evidence is kept; if blocking now is what the student needs to feel safe, safety comes first.

Reporting Routes (the DSL Decides Who Reports What)

- **The platform:** most apps let users report messages, posts and accounts.
- **Report Harmful Content (UK Safer Internet Centre):** reportharmfulcontent.com, for anyone 13 or over in the UK, about threats, bullying and harassment, impersonation, self-harm or suicide content and other harmful content, once you have reported it to the platform and at least 48 hours have passed (for people aged 13 and over; the DSL or a parent can report for a younger student). It cannot take reports of sexual images of under-18s (Report Harmful Content).
- **Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation):** helps under-18s get a nude or sexual image of themselves removed online, at childline.org.uk.
- **CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency):** ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse or grooming. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking (CEOP). Use it where there are signs of sexual contact, requests for images or grooming; if a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Under the Online Safety Act 2023, platforms likely to be used by children must protect them from content such as bullying and content that encourages self-harm, and Ofcom is the regulator (GOV.UK).

Support in School and Beyond

- Counselling or pastoral mentoring; a daily check-in with a named adult at first
- The tutor made aware (without details) so they can support
- A safe space at break and lunch, if they want one
- **Childline** (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at childline.org.uk (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- **Shout:** text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **Samaritans:** 116 123, free, any time, day or night
- **NHS 111:** call 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2), for urgent mental health help in England, any time, or use NHS 111 online



NOTIFY: Report the Concern

Tell the DSL as soon as is practicably possible. In this scenario there is immediate risk, so that means immediately, in person, while another adult stays with the student. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Who and When

- Send a colleague or use the school's urgent system: "I need the DSL now. A student has shown me threats and messages encouraging self-harm."
- If the DSL is not available, go to a deputy. If neither can be reached, go to a senior leader. Don't wait until the end of the lesson or the day.
- Anyone can refer directly to children's social care if they believe a child is at risk; telling the DSL does not remove your own responsibility.

What to Tell the DSL

- Who the student is, where they are now, and who is with them
- What they showed you and said, in their words, and what they said when you asked about self-harm
- Any specific threat: a time, a place, knowledge of their address or route
- The platform, account name, and when the messages arrived; whether they are still arriving
- Whether any sexual content, requests for images or signs of an adult were involved
- What you have said and done so far, and what you told the student would happen next

▼ For the DSL: assessment, external agencies and parents

Most staff need only: tell the DSL, today, with the information above.

The DSL's Initial Actions

- Assess the self-harm risk now, with the school's mental health lead where available, and agree the route to support: counselling, the GP, children and young people's mental health services, NHS 111 (option 2 for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online) or 999
- Assess the threat: is it specific, credible, imminent? Plan the rest of today, including the journey home
- Decide how evidence is preserved (for example, the family keeping the messages, or the device going to the police), never copying intimate images, and following UKCIS and DfE searching guidance
- Consider the police, including where messages may be threats, encouragement to self-harm, harassment or hate crime
- Where the police are involved, agree with them what is said to the other student's family, and when, before any contact (compare KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 599 and 603)

- Plan contact with any students identified as responsible, and their parents, so that it does not increase risk; apply the behaviour and anti-bullying policies alongside the child protection policy
- Where the Information Sharing Duty applies (from 30 September 2026), apply its three tests: share information that is relevant to safeguarding or promoting the child's welfare (Relevance) and may help the recipient to safeguard or promote their welfare (May facilitate), unless sharing would be more detrimental to the child than not sharing (Detriment), which applies only in extremely limited circumstances; record the decision to share or not share, with the rationale, and be transparent with the young person unless that would increase the risk. Data protection law still applies to how information is shared
- Record on the safeguarding system, with a chronology, and set review dates

When to Involve Other Agencies

Agency	When
Police (999 or 101)	Threats of death or serious harm; encouragement to self-harm or suicide; harassment; hate crime; any immediate danger; to identify an anonymous account holder
Children's social care	Significant harm or risk of it; concerns at home; where the student's safety cannot be managed with school and family support
Mental health services	Self-harm or suicide risk; assessment and therapeutic support; NHS 111 option 2 for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online; 999 in an emergency
CEOP (National Crime Agency)	Online sexual abuse or grooming, or an adult seeking sexual contact. Not for bullying, fake accounts or hacking
Report Harmful Content; Professionals Online Safety Helpline	Where a platform has not acted on a report made at least 48 hours earlier; advice for staff on online incidents

Where a Student Is 18

At 18 a student is legally an adult. The child safeguarding framework in KCSIE applies to under-18s, but the school still has welfare responsibilities. Where an 18-year-old is involved, the DSL considers adult safeguarding, police and welfare pathways alongside the school's procedures, and the adult student's own views and consent in a different way. This matters in sixth form and in boarding, where students turn 18 during their final year.

Before Contacting Parents or Carers

Parents will usually be told the same day. First consider whether telling them could increase the risk: for example, a reaction that could make self-harm more likely, the messages coming from someone in or connected to the household, or wider concerns at home. Where it could, seek advice from children's social care or the police first and agree a safe plan. Talk with the student about how their parents will be told.

Parent contact: the student targeted

- "We need to talk to you about [name]. They've shown us messages from an account that has been threatening them, and some of the messages encourage them to hurt themselves. [Name] is safe and with us now."
- "Please don't reply to the account, contact anyone you suspect, or post about it. Keep the messages. Have you noticed any changes at home?"

Parent contact: a student identified as responsible

- "We need to talk to you about [name]'s involvement in messages sent to another student, which included [threats / encouragement to self-harm]. This is serious, and we are following our safeguarding and behaviour procedures."
- "We also want to understand what's going on for [name], and make sure they get support. Please keep [name]'s phone and accounts as they are, and don't delete anything, until we have agreed next steps."

D

DOCUMENT: Record Observations

Record as soon as is practicably possible, on the school's safeguarding system, using GOLD. Your record may be used by other agencies, including the police. Record what you saw; don't attach copies unless the DSL decides to.

GOLD

Ground

Date, time, place, who was present, who you are, and how it came to your attention

Observe

What you saw and heard, with exact words in quotation marks

Language

Neutral, factual and non-diagnostic. No opinions or labels

Do

What you did, what you said would happen next, and why

Example: Exact Words and What You Saw

- Student said: "They said they know where I live and they're going to get me after school."
- Student said: "They keep telling me to hurt myself. Sometimes I think about it."
- When asked about self-harm, student said: "I haven't done anything, but I've thought about it this week."
- Seen on the student's phone at 10:42, as shown by the student: messages on [platform] from the account "[account name]", dated [dates]. One read: "watch your back after school". Two told the student to hurt themselves.

Recording template

SAFEGUARDING CONCERN: ONLINE ABUSE (THREATS AND ENCOURAGEMENT TO SELF-HARM)

Date and time:

Student: name, year, tutor group

Recorded by: name and role

Where and how it came to your attention:

WHAT THE STUDENT SAID (exact words in quotation marks):

WHAT I SAW (only what the student showed me):

Platform / app:

Account name(s) as shown:

Dates and times of messages:

Words of any threat or self-harm message, as they appeared:

Still arriving? Other platforms?

SELF-HARM: what I asked, and what the student said

THREAT: any time, place or personal information mentioned

ANYTHING SEXUAL, REQUESTS FOR IMAGES OR SIGNS OF AN ADULT: yes / no / details
(never copy or describe an image)

OBSERVATIONS (presentation, emotional state):

WHAT I DID AND SAID (with times):

EVIDENCE: what I did NOT do (no copies, no forwarding); what the DSL decided
SHARED WITH: DSL (name, time, how)
THE STUDENT'S WISHES AND VIEWS:
Signed and dated:

What Not to Record

- Your guesses about who is behind the account, or opinions about any student
- Your emotional reaction ("I was horrified")
- Content of any intimate image. Record that one was mentioned or appeared; never copy, attach or describe it
- Screenshots or copies attached to the record, unless the DSL has decided that is how evidence is kept

Online Context: Platforms, Evidence and Reporting

For many young people, online and offline life are one life. Online abuse follows them home and into the evening, and it rarely stays on one platform.

What Staff Do

- Believe, protect, report: you don't need technical knowledge
- Look only at what the student shows you; never search their phone
- Note the platform, account name and times; the DSL decides about evidence
- Never view, copy, forward or delete nude or semi-nude images (UKCIS)

Fake and AI-Generated Content

Edited or AI-generated images, videos, audio and fake profiles can be used to humiliate or threaten. The harm is real whether or not the content is. Never ask the student to prove whether it is genuine: "Whether it's real or not, this is serious, and it isn't your fault." KCSIE 2026 includes explicit images generated using AI among the "conduct" risks of online safety (paragraph 165). If content is sexual, follow the UKCIS route.

Phones and the School Day

KCSIE 2026 expects schools to be mobile phone-free environments by default (paragraph 170), but abuse sent in the evening still comes into school, so ask about evenings, weekends and group chats. Online safety should run through the whole school approach (paragraphs 166 and 169). Staff who need advice on an online incident can contact the Professionals Online Safety Helpline.



Boarding and Residential Life

For boarders, school is also home. There is no end of the school day, and a phone in a bedroom at night can be where the worst messages arrive.

Step	In boarding
● Recognise	Use the 4 Ps for the house: messages often arrive in the evening, after lights out or at weekends, and house group chats can turn on one boarder. Notice a boarder who is up late on their phone or avoids the common room.
● Engage	Boarders often tell house staff at informal times, such as late evening. Use TED and the script. Talk in a visible space, and let another adult know.
● Support	Safety tonight comes first: if there is any self-harm risk, the DSL plans supervision and checks overnight with the duty team. Agree with the boarder what happens to their phone tonight; taking it away can feel like punishment.
● Pause	Consider the whole house: the student responsible may live in the same house. Don't investigate, search phones, or speak to suspected boarders. If there is immediate risk, don't wait until morning.
● Offer	Model alternatives: house expectations about group chats, sharing and phones at night; older boarders as positive role models. If in doubt, N before O.
● Notify	Contact the on-call DSL or boarding deputy DSL straight away. If a child is in immediate danger and no DSL can be reached, call 999; out of hours, contact the local authority's emergency duty team.
● Document	Record on the safeguarding system before you go off duty, using GOLD. A house log or handover note is not a substitute.

Boarders' Routes to Help

- **Boarders can always contact their house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.** Make sure every boarder knows how.
- An independent person outside the staff whom boarders can contact directly (NMS 11.4), often called the independent listener
- Boarders must be able to contact their families privately; monitoring of communications should be proportionate (NMS 12.1)
- International boarders: agree with the DSL who contacts parents or guardians, when, and in what language, using interpreters where needed

Source: National Minimum Standards for Boarding Schools (2026).

For international boarders, abuse may continue in the holidays or come from other time zones.

Identity and Intersecting Harm

Online abuse often targets who someone is. KCSIE 2026 lists discriminatory behaviour, including racism, faith-targeted abuse and other prejudice-based incidents, as child-on-child abuse (paragraph 37). Record prejudice-based incidents in line with school policy, and remember that hostility based on race, religion, disability, sexual orientation or transgender identity can make an offence a hate crime (CPS). That is for the police to decide.

- **Race and faith:** racist and faith-targeted memes, slurs and "jokes" in group chats are abuse, not banter. Students may minimise them to fit in.
- **LGBTQ+ students** may face threats to "out" them, and may not want their parents told why they are being targeted. The DSL considers this when planning parent contact. For under-18s: Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111.
- **Disabled students and students with SEND** may be targeted because of their disability, or find it harder to recognise manipulation. Some may be drawn into harming others without understanding the impact; the behaviour still needs addressing.
- **Sex and gender:** KCSIE 2026 recognises that for some forms of child-on-child abuse girls are more likely to be victims, while all of it is taken seriously (paragraph 193). Boys are targeted too. Where abuse is sexual, KCSIE Part five applies alongside this guide.
- **Students with existing mental health needs** are more likely to report being bullied online (NHS England, 2023). Treat encouragement to self-harm with particular urgency for a student already known to be struggling.

- **International and EAL students** may be targeted in another language or on platforms staff don't know. Ask, and use interpreters where needed.

Additional Resources and Support

For Students

- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at childline.org.uk (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **For under-18s, this is the place to start.**
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Samaritans: 116 123, free, any time, day or night
- Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation): helps under-18s get a nude or sexual image of themselves removed online, at childline.org.uk
- Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111

For Parents and Carers

- NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- YoungMinds Parents Helpline: 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- NHS 111: call 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2), for urgent mental health help in England, any time, or use NHS 111 online

For Staff

- Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff
- Professionals Online Safety Helpline (UK Safer Internet Centre): helpline@saferinternet.org.uk, Monday to Friday, for anyone working with children
- Childnet, *Cyberbullying guidance for schools*
- Department for Education, *Preventing and tackling bullying* (advice, 2017; current on GOV.UK)

- Report Harmful Content (UK Safer Internet Centre): reportharmfulcontent.com, for anyone 13 or over in the UK, about threats, bullying and harassment, impersonation, self-harm or suicide content and other harmful content, once you have reported it to the platform and at least 48 hours have passed
- CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency): ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse or grooming. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking

Statutory Guidance and Law

- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*
- HM Government, *Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026*
- Department for Education, *Information Sharing Duty: statutory guidance* (in force 30 September 2026)
- Department for Education, *RSHE statutory guidance* (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026)
- Department for Education, *National minimum standards for boarding schools* (2026)
- UKCIS, *Sharing nudes and semi-nudes: advice for education settings*
- Department for Education, *Searching, screening and confiscation* (guidance for schools)
- Education and Inspections Act 2006, section 89 (behaviour policy: preventing all forms of bullying)
- Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014, Schedule 1, paragraph 10 (anti-bullying strategy)
- Online Safety Act 2023, section 181 (threatening communications)
- Online Safety Act 2023, section 184 (encouraging or assisting serious self-harm)
- Malicious Communications Act 1988, section 1
- Protection from Harassment Act 1997, section 7 (course of conduct)
- Crown Prosecution Service, *Encouraging or assisting suicide* (Suicide Act 1961, section 2)
- Crown Prosecution Service, *Hate crime*

Figures and Practice

- Ofcom, *Children and Parents: Media Use and Attitudes Report* (published 21 May 2026)
- Office for National Statistics, *Online bullying in England and Wales: year ending March 2020* (latest release)
- NHS England, *Mental Health of Children and Young People in England, 2023: Part 4, social and economic context*
- Anti-Bullying Alliance, *Our definition of bullying*

Contacts, figures and legal references checked 28 September 2026. Verify at point of use.

Quick Reference Card

Immediate Danger Comes First

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response.

Recognise

- Threats of violence and encouragement to self-harm: two immediate risks
- Anxiety about the phone, withdrawal, tiredness, talk of being a burden
- Anonymous is not the same as a stranger, and not for you to trace
- No disclosure needed, and no need to wait for it to happen again

Respond

- "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- Ask directly about self-harm; stay with them
- Look only at what they show you; never copy, forward or search
- Don't promise secrecy, investigate or confront

Notify

- DSL immediately, in person; another adult stays with the student
- Life at risk or immediate danger: 999
- If in doubt, N before O
- The DSL decides about evidence, police, parents and platforms

Document

- GOLD: Ground, Observe, Language, Do
- Their words; platform, account name, times, the words of the threats

- No copies, no guesses about the sender, never describe an image

Key Numbers

- Emergency: 999; police non-emergency: 101
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Samaritans: 116 123, free, any time, day or night
- NHS 111: call 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2), for urgent mental health help in England, any time, or use NHS 111 online
- Your DSL: named in the school's safeguarding policy

Online Evidence: One Rule

- **Ordinary messages or posts a student has already shown you:** note what is relevant (platform, date, who, exact words) in your record. Don't ask to see more or scroll through a phone, especially where messages may be sexual, because they may contain images. Don't log in to accounts, search profiles or investigate, and never transfer anything to a personal device.
- **Nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18:** don't intentionally view, copy, screenshot, forward, save or delete them. Tell the DSL straight away. If you see one by accident, tell the DSL, ask for support if you need it, and record that it was seen and what you did, without describing the image (UKCIS).
- The DSL decides what happens to devices and content.

Your School's Contacts

This guide is generic. Schools add their own details here, or keep a completed copy with this card, so that anyone responding, including at night, has the routes to hand.

Contact	Name and how to reach them
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	
Deputy DSL(s)	
Out-of-hours and boarding on-call safeguarding contact	
How to record a concern (system or form)	
Local authority children's services front door	
Out-of-hours emergency duty team	
LADO (concerns about adults)	
Police: 999 (emergency); 101 (non-emergency)	

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Reference Scenarios · Staff Guide 3

Scenario 3: Cyberbullying and Online Abuse

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Aligned with: KCSIE 2026 | Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 | Information Sharing Duty (September 2026) | Online Safety Act 2023 | RSHE statutory guidance (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026) | NMS for Boarding Schools 2026 | UKCIS sharing nudes and semi-nudes advice

Last Updated: September 2026 | Next Review: September 2027, or on publication of KCSIE 2027 if sooner

For staff in schools and other settings working with children. You may share it with colleagues. Share the student and parent guides, not this page, with students and families.